

Shark Tank Dubai - Mal Plug-In Playbook

Abdallah Abu Sheikh | Personal Investor Appearance

Prepared by Mal Marketing

Purpose

Abdallah is appearing on Shark Tank Dubai as a **personal investor**, not representing Mal. These scenarios equip him with natural, conversational moments to drip-feed awareness of what Mal is building — no hard sells, no promises. The goal is **indirect brand seeding**: positioning Mal in the minds of viewers, fellow Sharks, and entrepreneurs as the future of banking in the region.

Guiding Principles

- **Variety is everything.** Not every plug should name Mal. Some should just plant a frustration. Some should be a question. Some should be a personal story. The audience should never feel a pattern.
 - **Tie it to the entrepreneur's pain.** Only plug when it genuinely connects to a problem the founder just described.
 - **Earn the curiosity.** The best plug is the one that makes people Google Abdallah after the episode airs — not because he pitched, but because he said something that stuck.
 - **One per episode, max.** Restraint is what makes it powerful.
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Delivery Style Guide

Each scenario uses a different approach. This is intentional.

Style	What it looks like	When to use
The Question		When you want the audience to sit with the problem

Style	What it looks like	When to use
	Ask the entrepreneur something that exposes a gap Mal fills — never answer it yourself	
The Frustration	Share a personal frustration as an investor/founder — no product mention at all	When the moment is too early for a name drop
The Aside	Briefly mention something you're working on, then immediately pivot back to the deal	When a Shark or founder opens the door naturally
The Credential	Reference a specific insight or stat that signals deep domain expertise	When you want to be seen as the financial infrastructure guy
The Offer Hook	Tie your investment offer to a future resource you can personally connect them with	When you're actually investing in the deal
The Redirect	Respond to another Shark's comment by reframing the real problem	When another Shark says something about banking/finance you can build on

The 7 Scenarios

Scenario 1: The Freelancer / Cross-Border Hustler

Trigger: An entrepreneur earning in USD or foreign currency mentions losing money on exchange rates, slow bank transfers, or SWIFT headaches.

Style: The Question

"Can I ask you something — when you receive a payment from a client abroad, how much of that actually lands in your account? ... Right. So you're losing, what, 3-5% every single time? And you're okay with that? Because I'm not. That's one of the things that made me start my own company — I just couldn't accept that moving your own money should cost you that much."

Why it works: He never says "Mal." He never describes the product. He asks a question every freelancer in the audience is now doing the math on, then drops that this frustration is what made him start his own company. The curious viewer Googles him. That's the whole play.

Scenario 2: The Struggling SME Seeking Capital

Trigger: A small business owner talks about being rejected by banks, needing working capital, or struggling with cash flow despite having real revenue and paying customers.

Style: The Frustration + Redirect

"This is what breaks my heart about this region. You have a founder sitting here who sells every single day — real customers, real revenue — and a bank told them no because of a spreadsheet. The system is broken. Banks don't lend based on your business; they lend based on their own risk models that were built for a completely different world. That's actually why I left banking to build what I'm building now — but that's a conversation for another day. Right now, I want to talk about your margins..."

Why it works: He validates the founder, calls out the broken system (which resonates with every SME owner watching), hints that he's building the alternative, then deliberately cuts himself off and pivots back to the deal. The "conversation for another day" line is the hook — it signals there's a story without telling it.

Scenario 3: The Young Founder Who Doesn't Know Their Numbers

Trigger: An entrepreneur can't articulate their margins, doesn't know where their money goes, or admits they're flying blind on finances. Another Shark might roast them for it.

Style: The Credential

"I'm not going to roast you for that — honestly, I think the bigger question is why is it still so hard to know where your money is going in 2026? We all have AI that can write essays and generate images, but you still can't ask your bank 'where did my money go this month?' and get a straight answer. That's a design failure, not a you failure. My advice —

and this has nothing to do with whether I invest — find a tool that actually talks to all your accounts and gives you answers in plain language. They're coming. Trust me."

Why it works: Zero product mention. Zero brand mention. But he just described Mal's PFM product on national television and told the audience "they're coming — trust me." The wink is subtle enough that it doesn't feel like a pitch, but anyone paying attention connects the dots when they see what his company does.

Scenario 4: The Car / Mobility / Automotive Pitch

Trigger: An entrepreneur pitches anything related to cars, mobility, car services, used car platforms, or automotive tech.

Style: The Aside

"I love this space. I'll tell you one thing I've learned — the pain in car buying isn't finding the car. Everyone's solved discovery. The pain is what happens after: the financing. You go to a bank, they take a week, maybe they say no, mountains of paperwork. We're actually working on something in this exact space — fully digital, Sharia-compliant, offer in under 10 minutes from your phone. But look, that's my world — let's talk about yours. Walk me through your unit economics."

Why it works: This is the only scenario where he describes the product in some detail — but he does it in one breath and immediately pivots back. It feels like a founder who can't help but geek out about his space for a second, not someone running a commercial. The specificity ("10 minutes from your phone") is what sticks.

Scenario 5: The Family-Focused or Education Business

Trigger: An entrepreneur pitches something related to families, children, education, school fees, edtech, or childcare. Or the conversation turns to the cost of raising kids in the UAE.

Style: The Personal Story

"Did you know that a huge number of families in this country are paying school tuition on credit cards? Just to get through the term. And it's not because they can't afford it — it's because nobody's given them a better option that actually fits how they want to manage their money. That really stuck with me as a father. It's one of the reasons I do what I do outside of this show — I believe families here deserve financial tools that understand their life. Your kid's fees are due in September, your bank should already know that and help you get there. Anyway — I love what you're building. Let's talk numbers."

Why it works: He leads with a real, relatable stat that every parent in the UAE recognizes — credit card tuition payments — which frames the problem as systemic, not a criticism of the country. He never says "Mal," never says "product," but every parent watching just felt seen. And when they look up who Abdallah is and what he's building, the connection is instant.

Scenario 6: The Health / Wellness / Medical Startup

Trigger: An entrepreneur pitches a health, wellness, fertility, or medical services platform. Or the conversation touches on the cost of healthcare in the UAE.

Style: The Redirect (responding to another Shark)

"[After another Shark comments on the healthcare market size or cost] You know what nobody talks about though? The financing side. I know couples who've delayed starting a family — not because the treatment isn't available, but because paying for it feels impossible or the options available don't sit right with their values. That gap between 'the treatment exists' and 'I can actually afford it the right way' — that's a massive, massive gap. And very few people are working on closing it."

Why it works: He's responding to another Shark, not pitching. He's sharing something he's observed, not selling. He says "very few people are working on closing it" — and leaves the audience to figure out that he's one of them. This is the most indirect plug in the playbook, and probably the most powerful one because of it.

Scenario 7: The Scaling Business That's Outgrowing Its Tools

Trigger: An entrepreneur mentions operational chaos — juggling platforms for payroll, accounting, payments, compliance — or says they need to hire internationally and manage multiple currencies.

Style: The Offer Hook

"Here's what I'll say — I want to invest, and here's why: your product is strong, your team is strong, but your back office is going to kill you at scale. You're running payroll on one system, banking on another, compliance somewhere else, and none of them talk to each other. That's not a you problem — every SME in this region hits that wall. Part of the reason I want to be in this deal is that I'm personally very deep in the financial infrastructure space, and I think I can connect you to tools and systems that will collapse all of that into one place. So my offer is [X] for [Y]%, and I'm not just writing a cheque — I'm bringing you infrastructure."

Why it works: This is the boldest play — he's tying his investment offer to his expertise in Mal's exact space without naming Mal. "I'm personally very deep in the financial infrastructure space" and "I can connect you to tools and systems" is the kind of line that makes the other Sharks ask questions off-camera. And when they do, that's when the real conversation about Mal happens — not on the show, but after it.

Quick Reference Card

#	Trigger	Style	Mal Named?	Product Seeded	Key Line
1	Cross-border payments / FX loss	The Question	No	Global Accounts	"How much actually lands in your account?"
2	Can't get a bank loan	Frustration + Redirect	No (hints)	SME Lending	"That's why I left banking to build what I'm building now"
3	Founder doesn't know their numbers	The Credential	No	PFM	"They're coming. Trust me."

#	Trigger	Style	Mal Named?	Product Seeded	Key Line
4	Cars / automotive / mobility	The Aside	No (describes it)	Auto Financing	"Offer in under 10 minutes from your phone"
5	Family / education / school fees	Personal Story	No	Retail Banking (Tuition)	"One of the reasons I do what I do outside of this show"
6	Health / medical / fertility	The Redirect	No	MalHealth	"Very few people are working on closing it"
7	Scaling business / operational chaos	The Offer Hook	No	SME Banking (Full OS)	"I'm bringing you infrastructure"

Bonus: Universal Closer

If any Shark, host, or entrepreneur asks *"What is it that you're building?"* or *"Tell us about your company"*, Abdallah has one line:

"We're building the financial backbone for this region — for people and for businesses. Sharia-compliant, AI-native, and designed for how people here actually live. That's all I'll say for now."

Short. Mysterious. Moves on.

Do's and Don'ts

Do: - Mix up delivery styles — never use the same approach twice in a season - Let the silence do the work after a strong line — don't over-explain - Pivot back to the deal immediately after a plug — show you're there to invest, not advertise - Use "I" and "me" more than "we" — it's a personal appearance - Save the best plug for the episode with the highest emotional stakes

Don't: - Say "at Mal we're building" more than once across the entire season - Name the product (MalHealth, MalTuition, etc.) on camera — those are internal names - Promise any entrepreneur access to Mal's services as part of a deal - Plug in back-to-back episodes — skip at least one episode between plugs - Use jargon (Murabaha, open finance framework, receivables financing) — keep it human - React if another Shark asks what you're building — smile, say "let's talk after," and move on